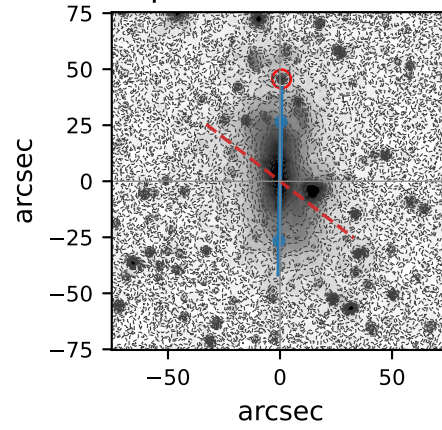
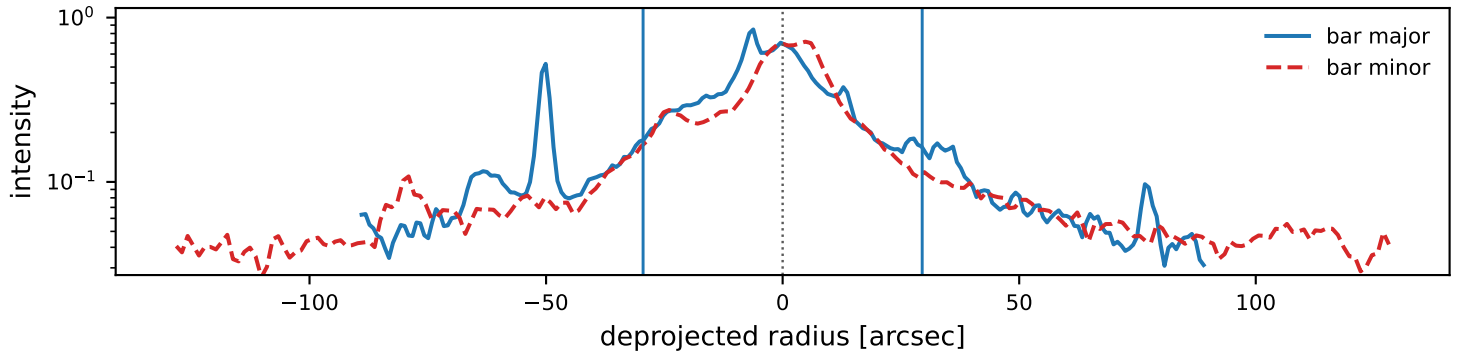


ESO440-044 foreground-mask profile comparison bar PA=179.0 deg

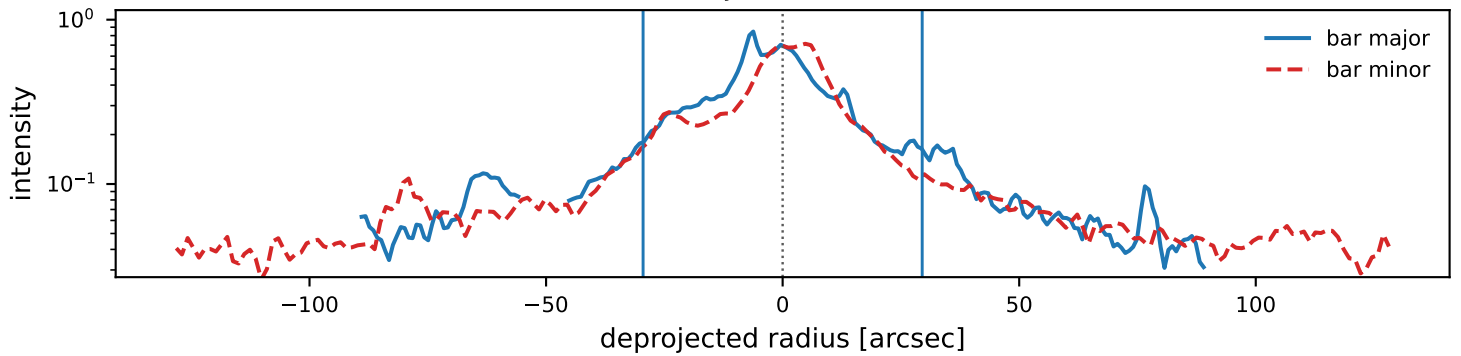
S4G 3.6 micron isophotes with masked objects circled



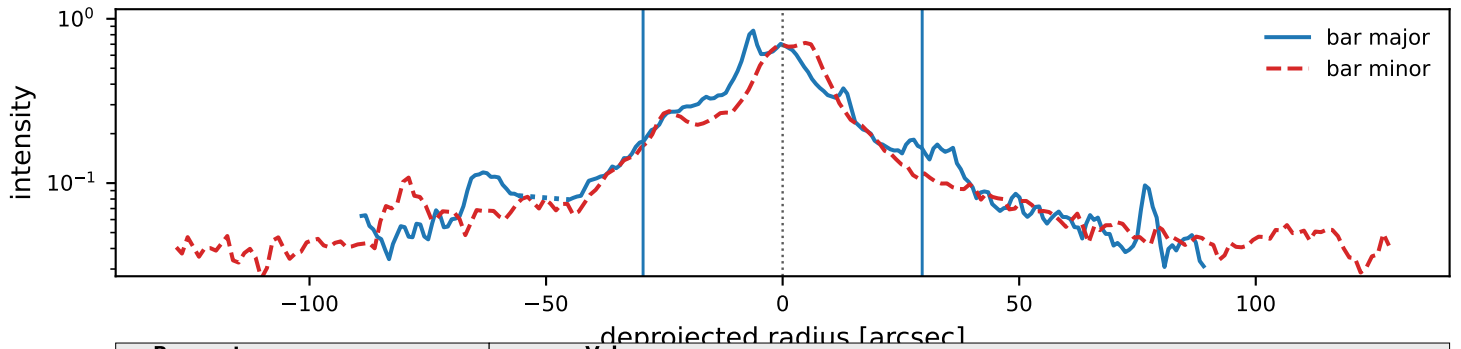
Original major/minor-axis cuts



Masked major/minor-axis cuts



Masked cuts with straight log-linear bridges



Parameter	Value
Masking model	spike-gated; photutils segmentation on residual image; photutils 3.0.0
Residual image	science image - Gaussian-smoothed galaxy model
Detection threshold	3.5 sigma above residual median
Profile spike gate	10 bar-major spike samples
Spike rule	peak $\geq$ 25% above 4-15 arcsec neighbours; $\geq$ 40% above $\pm$ 3 samples; $ r \geq$ 8 arcsec
Smooth sigma	15 px
Connected-pixel minimum	8 px
Dilation radius	3 px
Max segment area	500 px
Max elongation	6
Central exclusion radius	12 px
Profile width	3 px
Applied mask	1 source segments; 88 pixels ignored
Filled-profile panel	solid=measured data; fine dotted=samples filled by straight log-intensity bridge
Bridge merge gap	12 profile samples
Auto-tune grid	5, 4.5, 4, 3.5 sigma; selected 3.5 sigma